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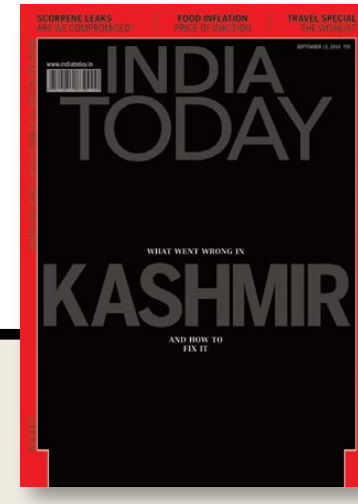
UNITED OPPOSITION Gupkar alliance leaders Farooq Abdullah, Mehbooba Mufti, M.Y. Tarigami and others speak to the media, Jammu, Dec. 21, 2021

only Pakistan-occupied Kashmir remained disputed territory.

Swift though the move seemed, accompanied by the house arrest of prominent Kashmiri leaders and a communications lockdown, it had long been in the making. Disquiet had never left the Valley, with stone-pelting becoming a new grammar of protest for the youth, a sentiment that only intensified after the death of young Hizbul commander Burhan Wani in 2016. The BJP's experiment at a coalition government with Mehbooba Mufti's PDP collapsed in June 2018, paving the way for Governor's rule.

Meanwhile, Pakistan's machinations continued. In September 2016, an attack on the brigade headquarters at Uri claimed the lives of 18 Indian soldiers. In February 2019, a suicide bombing in Pulwama killed 40 personnel of the CRPF.

Has the abrogation ended unrest, resolved political uncertainty, and set Kashmir on a path to development? That remains open to debate. J&K held its first election after its changed status in September–October 2024, with the National Conference emerging victorious and Omar Abdullah becoming chief minister. Yet while elected authority returned, the real power continues to lie elsewhere. The Valley has also not overcome the humiliation of its disempowerment, with the restoration of statehood remaining a persistent demand. Any illusion of normalcy was brutally shattered this April in Pahalgam, where terrorists killed 26 tourists, underscoring the fragility of peace in Kashmir. ■



What Went Wrong in Kashmir
Sept. 12, 2016

"History seems sometimes to move with the infinite slowness of a glacier and sometimes to rush forward in a torrent, Lord Louis Mountbatten once remarked. Nowhere is this more true than in Kashmir, where history has sometimes stood absolutely still.... History also periodically flows with the speed of river rapids in Kashmir, engulfing the vale in strife and blood, as it is doing now. After Kashmir erupted in protest on July 8, when Burhan Wani, the poster boy of the new militancy, was killed in an encounter with security forces, over 71 people have died."



The Promise and the Peril
Jul. 26, 2021

"Providing jobs to the Valley's youth is critical to channelling their energies into productive work and away from the lure of the gun. Unless this happens, security forces believe their hard-fought gains will soon dissipate."